to its north in the Mashko sector; Pts 5140, 4700 and 5100 to the north of Tololing in the Dras sector; Pt 5203 and the Jubar area in the Batalik Sector. Towards the end it became an unequal fight, with the situation getting more and more precarious and hopeless for the Pakistani troops with each passing day.

The real villains of this sad chapter of Pakistan's history will only be exposed if an official review of the events leading to the Kargil war and the operational handling of the conflict is undertaken in Pakistan. The whole edifice of lies and subterfuge will be shattered, but so will the national honour. Hence, the cloak of secrecy is unlikely to be lifted officially in the forseeable future. But can the people of the Northern Areas and other Pakistanis whose kith and kin were used as cannon fodder, and what is worse, were left abandoned in the battlefield without proper burial, ever forget it? This has happened earlier too – one has only to look at the misadventures of Pakistan in 1947 and 1965. It was reassuring to read that 'the PPP-led Government has decided to close the gates for any Kargil-like misadventure in future through legislation that will require the Cabinet's approval for declaration of war'.[6]

The ill-conceived and Machiavellian Pakistani plan was based on wrong assumptions and a foundation of deniability. As I saw it in my assignment as the ADGMO in the Army HQ, where we had to grapple with the challenge in Kargil, and in higher appointments later on, the following points stood out:

- Operation Badr was based on secrecy, deception and the belief that once Pakistani soldiers had secured the peaks, their positions would be unassailable. Their ingression would present a fait accompli, and their contention that the LoC was vague might even get accepted by the world.
- The planners underestimated the resolve and determination of the Indian Army to throw them out, and the guts to take the casualties that were inevitable. They thought that the Indians would acquiesce.